



General Guide

The strategy behind all four essays: what Chevening is actually funding, the evidence rules, and how to build one coherent thread across your application.

ABOUT THE EXAMPLES.

Every example in these guides is an anonymised and reinvented version of a successful essay. The people, institutions, universities, professors, schemes and statistics have all been changed, and are written only to demonstrate technique. In your own essays every name must be real, accurate and defensible at interview.

READ THIS BEFORE ANYTHING ELSE.

Chevening prohibits AI-generated answers and screens applications for plagiarism, fraud and machine-written text. These guides give you structure, not sentences. Copying any of it, or having a tool rewrite your draft, will get you disqualified.

1. What Chevening is actually buying

Chevening is not a prize for a good CV and it is not financial aid. It is the UK government taking a position in your career and expecting a return. The question behind every criterion is: if we fund this person, what will exist in ten years that would not otherwise have existed?

That reframing changes the writing task. You are not asking for tuition. You are making the case that you are an investment, and that the investment pays in two directions: a problem gets solved in your country, and a durable relationship is built with the UK.

The central principle

Do not try to sound impressive. Try to be convincing.

Those are different goals and they produce different sentences. An impressive essay tells the reader you are a leader. A convincing essay gives the reader enough evidence to conclude it themselves.

A Chevening essay is not a biography, a CV rewritten as prose, a list of achievements, a university brochure, or a collection of ambitious promises. It is an evidence-based argument about who you are, what you have already demonstrated, what you still need to learn, and what you intend to change.

Read across all four, the essays answer four questions in sequence:

1. Can you lead?
2. Can you build productive relationships?

3. Do you know exactly what you need to learn, and why?
4. Do you have a credible plan for converting that learning into impact?

The arc in one line: past evidence, then relationships, then capability gap, then UK learning, then future impact.

The four criteria

ESSAY	CRITERION	THE QUESTION BEHIND IT
1. Leadership experience	Leadership and influencing skills	Did things change because of you?
2. Relationship building and influence	Relationship-building skills	Do you turn relationships into outcomes?
3. Course choice and global challenge	Reasons for course and university choice	Does this course close a specific gap?
4. Career plan and impact	Commitment to long-term impact	Is the plan real, measurable and UK-connected?

Everything else on the form is read for consistency with the essays. Contradictions are among the fastest routes to rejection.

Being rejected is not a verdict. Many scholars applied more than once before being selected.

2. What the application asks of you

Four essays, each with four sub-questions. The sub-bullets are not decoration. Assessors mark against them. An answer that never says what it learned, or never names an obstacle, loses marks however well written. Treat each sub-bullet as a box that must be visibly ticked, then smooth the joins.

Tight word limits. Each box carries its own limit with a live counter, and the numbers are not published outside the form. Read the limit before you draft. These guides budget for roughly 300 words per essay; if your form differs, keep the proportions and scale.

Essay 3 covers your first-choice course only, tied to a single UK priority area.

Essay 4 covers medium and long term, three to five years and eight to ten, tied to a key challenge facing your country or region, with goals someone else could measure.

Work experience counts only after graduation. 2,800 hours, all gained after your undergraduate degree.

Your own words only, in English, throughout.

There is no CV. The form asks for your education history and your employment history, with each employment entry carrying its own description of your roles and responsibilities in around 100 words.

Those entries are the only record of your career that an assessor ever sees, which makes them a major piece of assessed writing rather than an administrative formality. Section 10 covers them in full.

3. The four UK priority areas

Use Chevening's own wording exactly:

- Promoting growth and prosperity
- Building resilience in a climate-vulnerable world
- Strengthening security and stability in a volatile world
- Supporting development for more inclusive and effective societies

Pick one. Name it in Essay 3 in a full sentence. Let it echo, without repeating, in Essay 4.

Most professional work fits two or three areas depending on framing, so this is a strategic choice. Pick the area where your evidence is strongest, not the one that sounds most urgent. A tax officer can file under growth and prosperity if the evidence is revenue and compliance, or under inclusive and effective societies if the evidence is state capability and fairness. Having chosen, stay inside it. An essay gesturing at three areas has chosen none.

Chevening also states a commitment to supporting under-represented groups, advancing women's leadership, and strengthening UK international alliances. If your work genuinely touches any of these, say so plainly. It costs a clause and it aligns you with a stated priority.

4. Mistakes that end an application before the essays are read

Citizenship. Apply from your country of citizenship wherever you live. Dual UK citizens are ineligible.

The work-hours arithmetic. Weeks multiplied by hours per week, toward 2,800. Recurring errors: entering months where weeks are asked, listing a job twice under two titles, and entering implausible hours. Roughly 35 to 60 hours a week across 40 to 50 weeks a year is the believable band.

Three different courses. Duplicates remove you from consideration.

English. The form must be completed in English or it is ineligible.

AI. Generated answers are prohibited, screened for and disqualifying, including having a tool polish your own draft.

Proofreading. Spelling, and above all the names of institutions and people. If your essays name a dozen organisations, as strong essays do, then a dozen spellings must be right.

5. STARL: the spine of Essays 1 and 2

Chevening's committees recommend STAR. The prompts add a fifth beat by asking what you learned. The working structure is STARL.

LETTER	WHAT IT ANSWERS	HOW IT USUALLY FAILS
S. Situation	What was broken, and how big was it?	Autobiography or a definition instead of the problem
T. Task	What became your job, under what constraint, with what at stake?	Skipped, leaving achievements ambiguously credited
A. Action	What did you personally decide and do, and whom did you move?	Activities with no decisions in them
R. Result	What moved, by how much, and what followed?	Adjectives where numbers should be
L. Learning	What do you now do differently?	A platitude about leadership

Roughly half the marks sit in R and L. Protect them when you cut.

Converting a raw memory into STARL

	RAW VERSION	STARL VERSION
S	"I worked on our medicine supply problem."	"A third of clinics in Molo District ran out of first-line antimalarials at least once last quarter, while the Central Medical Store held nine months of cover."
T	"I was on the supply chain team."	"The Director of Pharmacy Services asked me to find the cause before the next procurement round: eight weeks, no budget for new systems, and a quarter of the district drug budget at risk if we simply reordered."
A	"I coordinated with stakeholders and improved ordering."	"I traced 43 order cycles by hand, found reorder triggers set on annual averages rather than seasonal demand, rebuilt the trigger table with the Store's data team, and piloted it in six clinics."
R	"Things improved a lot."	"Stockouts in the pilot clinics fell from eleven to two the following quarter, and the Central Medical Store adopted the trigger table across all 43 facilities."
L	"I learned the value of teamwork."	"I learned that a shortage is often a signalling problem wearing the costume of a supply problem. I now interrogate the data a system already holds before anyone proposes buying anything."

Every cell on the right contains a name or a number somebody could check. That is the whole difference.

6. Evidence: the underlying rules

The master formula

Underneath STARL sits a sequence that applies wherever you describe an experience, in any essay.

Problem, then personal action, then influence, then outcome, then lesson, then future application.

The influence step is the one most often missing. Doing something yourself is delivery. Getting other people to act differently is leadership, and it needs naming: who they were, what they thought before, what changed their minds.

The evidence hierarchy

RANK	TYPE OF EVIDENCE	WHAT IT SHOWS
1	Transformation	Something changed because of what you did
2	Influence	You persuaded, mobilised, mentored or coordinated others
3	Responsibility	You took ownership of a problem nobody had claimed
4	Decision-making	You made a consequential choice or changed strategy
5	Learning	The experience changed how you think or work
6	Application	You subsequently used what you learned elsewhere
7	Participation	You were involved in something

Participation is where most rejected essays spend their words. If your best story sits at rank six or seven, find a different story rather than better adjectives.

Replace claims with evidence

INSTEAD OF WRITING	WRITE ABOUT
"I am a passionate leader."	What you did that a reader would call leadership
"I have excellent networking skills."	One relationship you built, and what it produced
"This is a world-class university."	The specific feature that closes your capability gap
"I want to make a positive impact."	The problem, your method, and what will be different
"I will improve my country."	The sector, the institution, the change, the measure

Numbers, and the precision rule

Aim for at least two concrete figures in every essay, placed at the outcome.

Use the exact number, not the rounded one. 1,281 polling stations rather than "over a thousand". 43 clinics rather than "dozens". 68 per cent rather than "roughly two thirds". A round number reads as an estimate; an odd number reads as something you measured. This is one of the cheapest credibility gains available and almost nobody uses it deliberately.

Never manufacture a number. A panel will ask how you measured it. If your work genuinely has no metrics, use a concrete change of state instead: a process changed, an institution adopted a practice, a collaboration was established between bodies that had never worked together, a template you wrote is still in use, a service reached somewhere it had not. Each is checkable, which is the property that matters.

Authenticity

Never manufacture leadership, numbers, partnerships, outcomes, responsibilities, influence, achievements, future commitments or impact. The commonest version is not invention but quiet inflation of your role in a team achievement. Say what the team achieved and then state precisely what you contributed. A modest contribution described accurately reads as credible; a large one described vaguely reads as evasive.

Your strongest essay is not the one containing your biggest achievement. It is the one containing your strongest evidence.

7. Strategic naming

This is the technique that separates strong Chevening essays from competent ones, and it runs through all four answers rather than only the course essay.

Why naming works

A name does two jobs at once. It makes the claim checkable, which is what converts an assertion into evidence. And it locates you inside a professional world that reaches decision-makers, which is precisely what Chevening is investing in.

Compare:

"I worked with senior officials to improve access to identity documents."

"I briefed Dr Amina Sesay, the Registrar General, whose office then appointed me to the Civil Registration Technical Advisory Group."

The second is barely longer. It contains a person, a title, an institution, an appointment and an implied relationship, and every element of it could be verified.

The rule

Name the person or institution, and in the same sentence say what you did with them.

A name with a working relationship attached is evidence. A name with nothing attached is a list of contacts, which is exactly the failure Chevening's committees warn against. The difference is not whether you name people. It is whether the naming is doing work.

WEAK, A CONTACT LIST	STRONG, A WORKING RELATIONSHIP
"I have worked with the Ministry of Health, the World Bank and several universities."	"I ran the district pilot with the Ministry of Health's Quality Assurance Unit, which adopted the referral form as its default in 2025."
"I have met the Registrar General."	"The Registrar General appointed me to the technical advisory group after my three-province study."
"I know Professor Aird's work."	"Professor Aird supervised the chapter I contributed to her edited volume on frontline service design."

What is worth naming

- **People, with their title attached.** The title carries the information. "Dr Samuel Boateng, chair of the National Water Tariff Commission" tells the reader where in the system he sits, which is why the relationship matters.
- **Your own institutions**, including small ones. A district office named is stronger than "my organisation".
- **Named schemes, programmes and funds** you have worked on.
- **National strategies and policy documents** that already name your problem.
- **Bilateral frameworks and donor programmes**, in the funder's own wording. Citing an FCDO priority area or a named UK partnership framework by its exact title signals that you read the strategy documents of the institution you are asking for money.
- **Conferences, fellowships and appointments** you were selected for, with the selecting body named.
- **Academic modules, research centres and faculty**, in Essay 3.
- **The artefact that changed:** the guideline, the dataset, the form, the standard operating procedure, the framework, by its actual name.

Density

Aim for roughly four to eight proper nouns in a 300-word essay. Fewer and the essay floats free of the world. More and it becomes a directory. Every one of them should be attached to a verb describing what you did.

When not to name

Do not name individuals who are beneficiaries, patients, clients or minors, or anyone whose identification could expose them. Use their role instead. The naming rule applies to institutions and to professional counterparts, not to the people you serve.

Do not name someone you barely know in the hope that recognition transfers. Interview panels ask follow-up questions about relationships, and a name you cannot discuss for two minutes is a liability rather than an asset.

8. Twenty structural moves that make essays work

Use five or six of these deliberately. Using all twenty would be unreadable.

Opening moves

1. The diagnostic opening. Name what kind of problem it is, in a sentence only a practitioner could write. "Low registration coverage here is not a demand problem but an administrative one."

2. The contradiction. Two facts that should not coexist, side by side. Clinics without stock while the store is full. Ninety per cent phone ownership with ten per cent digital payment use.

3. Lived experience, converted immediately. If you belong to the group you serve, or come from the region you will return to, say so in the first two sentences and convert it into evidence within the same breath. "I grew up in Katiba Province, where fewer than half of children hold a birth certificate; I now run the registration research that measures why." The personal stake earns you the standing to define the problem, and it doubles as your answer to why you will actually return.

4. The scarcity claim. "I am one of perhaps six people in the country working on this." "There is no national expertise in this area at all." This answers the question of why fund you rather than the next applicant, and it makes the counterfactual vivid. Use it only where it is true and where you could defend it.

Evidence moves

5. The named initiative. Give what you built a proper name. A named service, project or programme reads as something you founded. "My responsibilities included" reads as something you were handed. The founding act is itself the credential.

6. External appointment and selection, stated flatly. Somebody else has already bet on you. Appointed to a commission, selected for a named fellowship with the funder identified, elected by your peers, asked to advise a named office. Four words each, and worth more than any amount of self-assessment.

7. The obstacle chain. Act, hit a constraint, adapt, act again. Each decision visibly caused by something you learned.

8. The adaptation beat. One thing that failed, honestly reported, and the redesign it forced. An essay in which nothing goes wrong reads as luck or fiction.

9. Prioritisation under constraint. What you could not afford to do, and how you chose. "We had resources for a fifth of the district, so I targeted the twenty villages with the lowest baseline coverage."

10. Odd numbers. 1,281 rather than "over a thousand". Precision reads as measurement.

11. The impact ladder. Results at three levels: national or institutional, organisational, individual. "The dataset is now published quarterly; fourteen district offices have been trained; 214 families have completed late registration."

12. The named artefact. State exactly what changed and what it is called. Not "I advocated for reform" but "the pain measurement scale was incorporated into the national disability assessment guideline". This is the highest-value form of result available.

13. The micro-case. One sentence about one person, after the numbers, never before. It makes the essay memorable. One sentence only.

14. Insider vocabulary, lightly glossed. The shorthand practitioners in your field use with each other, explained in three words where a non-specialist would stumble. It signals membership of a professional community in a way careful general prose cannot.

Relationship moves

15. The escalation ladder. The relationship changes state over time: intern, then student, then colleague, then co-author. Time-stamped stages prove maintenance.

16. Network multiplication, with the broker named. One relationship produces an introduction that produces an outcome. "Mr Adeyemi introduced me to the district committee chair, which is how the proposal reached the agenda."

Forward-looking moves

17. The zoom. Give the national statistic, then your own province or district. "Coverage nationally is 38 per cent; in Katiba Province, where I will return, it is 30." This proves you are going somewhere specific and makes the first year concrete.

18. Dated futures. By 2032, by 2035. Not "in the long term". A year is falsifiable, which is why it reads as serious.

19. The bilateral hook. One clause placing your work inside a real UK partnership framework, an FCDO programme in your sector, or a UK institution that already built what you intend to build.

20. The personal barrier fused with Chevening. The strongest barrier answers are about the applicant's own standing rather than about funding. "Advocacy from practitioners is routinely dismissed in our sector as anecdotal. I will meet that with primary evidence, a recognised research partner, and the institutional credibility the scholarship carries." This answers the barrier sub-question and the why-Chevening sub-question in one move.

9. Build the thread before you draft anything

The four essays must be four views of one professional life. Fill this in on one page first.

YOUR ANSWER

The problem I work on, in one specific sentence

The UK priority area it sits under

What I have already changed, with two exact numbers

The thing I founded, and its name

The appointment or selection somebody else gave me

The relationship that made the work possible, with name and title

The artefact that changed, by its actual name

What I still cannot do, meaning the capability gap

First-choice course, two modules, two academics

Year one back: where, with whom, measured how

Years three to five: the capability I build

Years eight to ten: the institution or system, with a date

The barrier I will genuinely hit, including barriers about me

What Chevening specifically unlocks

The altitude ladder

Strong sets rise through the four essays. Essay 1 sits at village, clinic or booth level. Essay 2 moves to coalitions, associations and officials. Essay 3 is the university and its international standing. Essay 4 is a national institution with regional reach. The ascent is what makes the set feel like a trajectory rather than four samples. Check for it explicitly: if Essay 4 operates at the same altitude as Essay 1, the plan is flat.

The recurring cast

Let people and institutions reappear across essays. The midwives' association from Essay 1 becomes a delivery partner in Essay 4. The official from Essay 2 chairs the committee your career plan runs through. This is a stronger form of coherence than merely keeping the topic consistent, because it shows one professional life rather than four separate arguments.

Worked thread

Invented, for shape only.

Fewer than half the children in Katiba Province hold a birth certificate, which locks them out of national exams and later out of land title. Priority area: supporting development for more inclusive and effective societies. I founded Kalima Registration Outreach, a mobile registration service that has registered 3,142 children across 40 villages and cut median distance to a registrar from 26km to 4km. It runs through the Katiba Midwives' Association, whose members now issue notification slips at delivery. On the strength of

the three-province study, Dr Amina Sesay, the Registrar General, appointed me to the Civil Registration Technical Advisory Group, where the late-registration procedure I drafted became national guidance in 2025. What I cannot do is evaluate whether the effect holds or cost it for national rollout. MSc Social Policy and Evaluation at Northgate University; modules in Impact Evaluation and Public Service Design; Professor Helen Aird on frontline incentives and Dr Marcus Oyelaran on how households actually use entitlements. Year one: replicate in Molo and Sisan, the two lowest-coverage districts, with the Provincial Registrar's office. Years three to five: build the evaluation function inside the National Civil Registration Authority. By 2035: quarterly national monitoring showing which districts fail which groups. Barrier: registrars are assessed on volume rather than coverage, so disaggregation makes them look worse. Chevening: the alumni fund to extend Kalima, and access to a UK registration service that solved this decades ago.

Every essay is now written in note form, and the cast recurs.

10. The work experience section

This is the most under-prepared part of the application, because most applicants misunderstand what it is.

Chevening does not ask for a CV. It asks for your education history, and for your employment history entered as separate entries, each with around 100 words describing your roles and responsibilities in your own words. Confirm the exact limit in the form.

That means these entries are not supporting material. They are the only place in the entire application where an assessor sees your actual career. The four essays cover a handful of chosen episodes; everything else about your working life exists here or nowhere.

Three consequences follow, and they change how much effort this deserves.

It is the largest piece of writing in the application. An applicant with six roles is writing around 600 words here, and the form allows many more entries than that. That is more than any single essay, and often more than two of them combined. It needs its own drafting session rather than being filled in at the end of a long evening.

It carries your progression on its own. There is no CV to display the arc from junior to senior, so the arc has to be visible across the entries themselves. Read top to bottom, they should show scope widening, autonomy increasing, and the rooms you are in getting more senior.

It corroborates the essays. If Essay 1 says you were appointed to a national advisory group, the entry for that job should show the role that made the appointment plausible. If Essay 4 names a delivery partner, the entry should show that you already work with them. Assessors read across, and an essay claim with no footing in the work history invites doubt about the claim rather than about the entry.

Five moves per entry

1. **Scope, with a number.** What you own and how big it is. Connections served, portfolio size, team size, budget, caseload, geography.

2. **Two or three responsibilities as verbs you own.** Designed, negotiated, rebuilt, drafted, trained, evaluated, chaired. Not "was responsible for" and not "assisted with".
3. **One responsibility that faces outward**, with the external body named. The committee you sit on, the ministry you brief, the association you represent the organisation to. Even junior roles usually have one.
4. **One measurable result** the essays can build on without repeating.
5. **Full sentences, first person, no bullet points.**

Gloss employers the assessor will not know

An assessor in London may have no idea what your organisation is. A short factual clause fixes that, and it costs almost nothing: *a national non-profit representing the technology industry, the state's largest referral hospital, a policy institute funded by the Ministry of Finance.*

This is not the same as the ranking language banned in Essay 3. There, "world-renowned" is worthless because the assessor already knows the university. Here, a plain description of an unfamiliar employer converts an unknown name into a known quantity, which is exactly what naming is supposed to do.

Keep it factual. *One of the country's three licensed credit bureaux* is a fact. *A highly reputable and prestigious organisation* is not.

Showing the arc

Read your entries in sequence and ask what is growing. Any of these will do it, and you rarely need more than one per entry:

- Scope: from one district to a province, from 40 loans to 8,000
- Team: from working alone to managing nine people
- Decision rights: from recommending to approving
- Money: from spending a budget to setting one
- Altitude: from reporting to your manager, to briefing a board, to sitting on a national committee
- Externality: from internal work to representing the organisation outside it

If two consecutive entries look identical in scope, the second one is under-described rather than genuinely flat. Find what changed.

The awkward cases

A sideways move or a step down. Describe what it gave you access to rather than apologising for it. Moving from a national body to a district office to run something directly is a legible choice if you say what you went there to do.

Self-employment or freelancing. State the client base, that you scope and price the work yourself, and who receives your output. Autonomy is the strength here, so make it explicit rather than letting the entry read as a gap.

Voluntary and unpaid roles. They belong here and Chevening's criteria value them. Write them exactly as you would a paid role. Note that only post-graduation experience counts toward the 2,800 hours.

Two roles at the same employer. Separate entries, with the second showing plainly what changed. If both read the same, the promotion is invisible and you have lost your clearest evidence of progression.

A job outside your field. Do not hide it and do not over-explain it. One factual entry, and if it built something you still use, say so in a clause.

Very early roles. Keep them short and factual. The 100 words is a limit, not a target, and a junior role padded to full length weakens the entries around it.

Four model entries

Public sector (98 words)

I run the non-revenue water programme at Katiba Water Utility, a municipally owned utility serving 340,000 connections, managing a field team of nine and the district metering budget. I set leak-detection priorities, negotiate excavation access with Katiba Municipal Council, and present quarterly performance to the utility board. I also chair the joint technical group with the National Water Regulatory Authority, where I drafted the reporting template now used for water losses nationally. Since I rebuilt our zoning and metering approach in 2024, losses in the pilot zones have fallen from 41 per cent to 28.

Private sector (99 words)

I manage credit risk at Sahel Trade Finance, one of the country's three licensed non-bank lenders to small traders, covering 8,140 active loans. I built and own the scoring model, set provisioning policy with the finance director, and chair the monthly arrears committee. I represent the firm on the Bankers' Association working group on responsible lending, where I drafted the affordability testing section of the 2025 code. Since I rebuilt the model to use cash-flow rather than collateral data, approvals for women-owned businesses have risen 34 per cent with no increase in default.

NGO (97 words)

I run the livelihoods programme at Ubuntu Futures, a national employment charity, across Molo and Sisan districts, managing eleven staff and an annual budget of £412,000. I design the training curriculum, negotiate placement agreements with employers, and report quarterly to the donor and to the District Commissioner's office. I sit on the district inter-agency coordination group, where I lead on employer engagement. Last year we placed 643 participants, 71 per cent of whom were still in work at six-month follow-up, and two employers have since hired independently of us.

Self-employed (94 words)

I run an independent policy research practice, working on commission for two regulators and three donor programmes. I scope and price each engagement, design the research, and present findings directly to commissioning officials rather than through an intermediary. I have built a standing panel of twelve field researchers whom I train and supervise across engagements. My 2025 study of licensing

costs for small operators was cited in the National Energy Regulatory Commission's consultation document, and its recommendation on tiered licensing was adopted.

Dos

- Give it a dedicated drafting session, before or alongside the essays
- One exact number per entry sizing what you were responsible for
- Verbs of decision rather than verbs of participation
- One outward-facing responsibility per entry, with the body named
- A factual gloss on any employer an assessor will not recognise
- Something visibly growing between consecutive entries
- Corroboration for every claim your essays make about your role
- The same voice as your essays
- Consistent spelling of every organisation, matching the essays exactly

Don'ts

- Paste bullet points from a CV, which is not what is being asked for
- Repeat sentences that already appear in your essays
- Inflate a title you will be asked about at interview
- Describe what the department achieved without separating your own part
- Fill 100 words with duties that carry no outcome
- Pad a junior role to the full limit
- Leave a role out because it feels irrelevant, or duplicate one under two titles
- Enter months where weeks are asked for, or hours nobody would believe

Checklist

- ☐ Every role since graduation entered once, with no duplicates
- ☐ Weeks and hours entered correctly and plausibly
- ☐ Each entry has scope, decision verbs, an outward-facing responsibility and a result
- ☐ Unfamiliar employers glossed in a factual clause
- ☐ Something grows between each consecutive pair of entries
- ☐ Every essay claim about a role is corroborated here
- ☐ No sentence repeated from an essay
- ☐ Organisation names spelled identically throughout the application
- ☐ Full sentences, first person, no bullet points

- ☐ I could expand on every entry for five minutes at interview

11. Word budgets

ESSAY	SPLIT AT 300 WORDS
1. Leadership, STARL	S 40, T 30, A 110, R 70, L 50
2. Relationships, STARL	S 55, T 35, A 90, R 50, L and Chevening 70
3. Course choice	problem and priority area 70, course and modules 110, university and faculty 60, immediate application 60
4. Career plan	impact intent 60, medium term 70, long term 70, barriers 55, Chevening 45

12. The writing process

Phase one: research

- ☐ Full module list and handbook for the first choice, not the marketing page
- ☐ Two academics, with one specific recent piece of work each, and their exact titles
- ☐ How the course is taught and assessed
- ☐ The research centre or institute attached to the programme
- ☐ Any departmental partnership with institutions in your country
- ☐ One national strategy or policy document that names your problem, by its title
- ☐ One UK institution, bilateral framework or FCDO programme in your sector, by its exact name
- ☐ Every statistic you intend to use, with its source
- ☐ The correct legal name and spelling of every organisation you will mention
- ☐ The capability gap written as a sentence beginning "I cannot currently"

Phase two: structure

One line per paragraph, checked against the sub-questions, with word counts assigned. Do not begin prose until the outline covers every sub-bullet.

Phase three: draft

One idea per paragraph, active voice, first person, specifics everywhere. Do not edit while drafting.

Phase four: cut

1. Delete every sentence that could appear unchanged in another applicant's essay.
2. Delete adjectives doing the work numbers should do: significant, tremendous, invaluable, impactful.
3. Replace weak verbs with decisions: helped becomes designed, worked on becomes rebuilt, was involved in becomes negotiated.
4. Replace round numbers with the exact figure wherever you have it.
5. Check every proper noun is attached to something you did.
6. Verify every figure, and remove any you cannot source.
7. Confirm every sub-question is still answered.
8. Read aloud, then give it to a colleague who knows your work.

13. Voice and style

Explain, do not list

There is no CV in this application, and the essays are not a substitute for one. Their job is not to tell the reader what you have done, which the work experience entries already cover. It is to answer why it mattered, what you personally did, what changed, what you learned and what you will do next.

So do not spend essay words listing degrees, certificates, publications, awards, conferences, workshops, memberships or job titles. Include any of them only where they advance the argument in that paragraph. A publication mentioned as evidence that you can produce policy-relevant research earns its place. A publication mentioned because you are proud of it does not.

Avoid the sophisticated English trap

Do not write: "I aspire to leverage my transformative leadership paradigm to catalyse multidimensional socioeconomic development."

Write: "I will use what I learn to redesign how Katiba allocates maintenance budgets."

A sophisticated idea expressed plainly beats an ornate sentence containing a vague one. Assessors are not marking your English. They are marking whether your case is credible.

Word economy

Delete on sight: "it is important to note that", "in my opinion", "as we all know", "in today's rapidly changing world", "I would like to take this opportunity to", "needless to say", "various stakeholders", and "in order to" where "to" will do.

Every paragraph must earn its place

Ask what it proves. It should contribute to leadership, influence, relationship-building, your capability gap, course fit, career progression, national relevance, future impact or Chevening relevance. If it is merely interesting, cut it.

Line-level rules

Do

- Write "I" for your own contribution, and attribute team work precisely
- Use full sentences throughout
- Prefer concrete nouns, including proper nouns
- Keep your own idiom where it is clear

Don't

- Use bullet points in the essay boxes
- Quote anyone, define abstract concepts, or open with a proverb
- Write "we" where you mean "I"
- Use passionate, dynamic, holistic, synergy, game-changing or impactful
- Import phrasing from university websites or policy boilerplate

14. Consistency across the four essays

- ☐ The problem in Essay 3 is recognisably the problem in Essays 1 and 2
- ☐ The capability gap in Essay 3 is one my experience in Essay 1 would plausibly have exposed
- ☐ At least one named person or institution recurs across essays
- ☐ The altitude rises from Essay 1 to Essay 4
- ☐ The first-year plan appears in Essay 3 and is not repeated in Essay 4
- ☐ The priority area is named once in Essay 3 and echoed in Essay 4
- ☐ Dates, titles and employers match the work history exactly
- ☐ My three course choices point at the same career
- ☐ No number appears twice with two different values
- ☐ Every organisation is spelled identically each time it appears
- ☐ Every claim my essays make about a role is corroborated in that role's work history entry
- ☐ No sentence appears in both an essay and a work history entry

15. Final quality control

Evidence

- ☐ At least two exact figures in each of Essays 1 and 2, at the result
- ☐ Every statistic sourced; anything unverifiable removed
- ☐ Four to eight proper nouns per essay, each attached to something I did
- ☐ Module names checked against the current handbook
- ☐ Every person, institution and scheme spelled correctly

Strategy

- ☐ One UK priority area, in Chevening's wording
- ☐ University justified on substance, never ranking
- ☐ A named role for the UK and for Chevening
- ☐ The career plan addresses a real challenge in my country or region

Mechanics

- ☐ Citizenship, work hours, three courses, English, word limits
- ☐ Written entirely by me

The test suite

The specificity test. For any abstract statement, ask who, what, why, how and what changed. "I empowered young people" becomes a real sentence only when those five are answered.

The so-what test. After every achievement, ask "so what?" and keep asking until the answer is something that changed for somebody else.

The name test. Circle every proper noun. Is each one attached to a verb describing what you did with it? Unattached names are a contact list and score nothing.

The job title test. Remove your job title from Essay 1. Do your actions still demonstrate leadership?

The network test. Does Essay 2 prove you build relationships that produce results, or only that you know people?

The university swap test. Replace your university's name with another. Does most of Essay 3 still work? If yes, it is generic.

The altitude test. Read the four essays in order. Does the scale of what you affect increase?

The why-you test. Would a reader understand why you in particular can carry out this plan?

The why-now test. Can a reader follow: I reached this stage, hit this limitation, now need this capability, this course provides it, I will apply it here?

The why-Chevening test. What becomes impossible, or much slower, without it?

The golden thread test. Read the first sentence of all four essays back to back. Do they form one storyline?

The colleague test. Would someone who works with you recognise this as you?

The interview test. Could you talk for five minutes about any claim, any name and any number, without notes?

The CV test. What does the reader now know that they could not have learned from your CV? If the answer is "many qualifications and ambitions", the essays are not finished.

16. Fifteen questions before you submit

1. Can the reader identify my strongest leadership example immediately?
2. Can the reader see exactly what I personally did?
3. Have I demonstrated influence rather than participation?
4. Have I shown what changed because of my actions?
5. Does my relationship example show a partnership rather than a contact list?
6. Have I said what I contributed to that relationship?
7. Is my capability gap unmistakably clear?
8. Does every course feature I mention address that gap directly?
9. Would my course argument survive a change of university name?
10. Have I named a credible priority for my future impact?
11. Are medium and long-term goals connected, with each stage enabling the next?
12. Can the reader see credible evidence that the impact will happen?
13. Have I named realistic barriers, including one about my own standing, with practical responses?
14. Is Chevening relevant to the plan rather than a source of funding?
15. Do all four essays tell one coherent story about the professional I am becoming?

The final rule. Do not tell the reader you are a leader. Give them enough evidence to conclude it. Do not tell them the university is world-class. Show them it provides precisely the capability you lack. Do not tell them you will improve your country. Show them the problem, the method, the partner, and what will be different.



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